removal of the ‘wounded,’ as well as the ‘maneuvers’ of the Cuban army.” As if that were not enough, “an hour or an hour and a half before the missile column set out on its itinerary, a specially formed column of Cuban trailers or heavy trucks was dispatched along false itineraries.” The Soviet columns included dozens of vehicles. First came “the motorcyclists with radio equipment; a Cuban vehicle with an operational officer, interpreter, and guards; two light vehicles with the commanders of the column; and a security vehicle,” wrote Statsenko. Only then did the “missiles and tractors, a crane, and extra tractors” follow. The procession ended with a “security vehicle with Cuban guards and motorcyclists with radio equipment.” The Soviet officers and soldiers were dressed in Cuban uniforms and prohibited to speak Russian. They would communicate with one another with the help of a couple of memorized Spanish words and phrases.[17]

The task of delivering the R-12 missiles to their assigned stations created numerous logistical problems. More than 22 meters long, the missiles were transported by even longer trailers. Statsenko, who personally supervised the movement of the first regiment of his division, gave Colonel Sidorov one week to prepare the route for his missiles from Casilda to an area near Calabazar de Sagua, approximately 100 kilometers as the crow flies but twice as far along narrow Cuban roads. In some places Sidorov and his men reinforced the bridges; elsewhere they built entirely new roads. Hardest of all was navigating the narrow streets of Cuban towns along the route. “In the town of Caunao,” recalled Sidorov, “there was a sharp right turn with a 30-degree incline. To obtain the requisite turning radius, it looked as if we would have to demolish a statue in honor of the first cosmonaut, Yurii Gagarin, and the three-story municipal building. There was no other way.” Eventually he found the solution: the column passed the city in one direction without making the tricky turn, got onto another road outside the town, reentered the town from a different direction, and passed through it again with no need to take the turn and demolish two of the city’s landmarks.[18]

By the end of September Statsenko and Sidorov had delivered the missiles and the rest of the equipment to the regiment’s designated stations. Now they had to build the launchpads from scratch, a task even more difficult than unloading and transporting the missiles. The Soviet soldiers,